

The Indie Founder Survival Guide: Self-Talk

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Self-Talk: What this means (and what most people miss)

Your negative self-talk is the voice in your head that's constantly speaking to you. Sometimes it's obvious, telling you that you haven't done enough, you're behind, or you're not a good enough friend. Other times it's more subtle, presenting as a steady anxiety or pressure, such as replaying conversations, comparing yourself to others, or never quite feeling good enough.

One of the clearest signs of heavy negative self-talk is ending the day stressed or depleted, regardless of the hours you put in. Some people blame this exhaustion on having too much on their plate, while others feel stuck and cannot figure out where their energy went. You tell yourself you will do more or be better, but lasting progress escapes you, leaving the constant reality that you beat yourself up for not making desired changes.

Your exhaustion actually comes from **pushing against that voice all day long**. The solution isn't managing life better; it is seeing that voice clearly and changing how you relate to it. When the pressure of the inner critic eases, your energy and clarity return naturally. Work feels lighter, decisions come faster, and you judge yourself and others far less.

What it feels like when your Self-Talk is becoming harsh

Your responses suggest your inner dialogue is mixed, sometimes kind and forgiving, and other times creating pressure and self-criticism. When the harsh voice is present, it sounds like a demanding boss or

bully. You not only believe this voice tends to be right, but you also think you need it to stay motivated.

You may notice you are more encouraging and forgiving toward your friends than toward yourself. Feeling restful and okay about yourself depends on your daily productivity or whether people seemed pleased with you. You might ruminate on mistakes for hours or days. At work, this takes a tremendous amount of energy and significantly hurts your productivity. Working on your self-talk unlocks more productivity, provides more energy, enjoyment, and ease throughout the day, and reduces your judgment of yourself and others.

Patterns to Explore

- **Judgments as mirrors:** Our judgments of others mirror our judgments of ourselves. We cannot welcome in others what we haven't welcomed in ourselves. Judging others is a clue about a part of yourself asking to be seen and accepted. Awareness of this is the first step to decreasing negative self-talk.
- **Defensiveness as a clue:** When words sting, ask how they echo what you already say to yourself. Defensiveness occurs when someone's words echo your inner critic's beliefs. This is a powerful way to uncover the stories you carry about yourself.
- **Burnout's hidden driver:** Stress and burnout stem from running on "dirty fuel" like pressure, self-criticism, or fear of failure. The voice in your head, not the workload, usually wears you down. Ending the day tense or wiped out means your motivation comes from threat and self-criticism. Tracking when work drains you helps spot negative self-talk.

One experiment for you to try this week: Transcribe your thoughts

1. **Step 1:** Transcribe every thought you have for 10 minutes. Pay attention to every thought, from mundane lunch musings to thinking the exercise is dumb. It is recommended to do this alone using voice-to-text on your phone.

2. **Step 2:** Skim the transcript and star anything self-critical or self-judgmental, including subtle pressure or anxiety. *Tip: star anything you wouldn't say to a friend or a standard you wouldn't set for them.*
3. **Step 3:** Read the list back at the end and repeat 3 times this week.